

Editing Sample: Before & After

Editing | Internal Communications, Web Copy, App Text, and Contract Language

Version: 1.1 (October 7, 2026)

Skills demonstrated: Clarity and tone editing, author queries, consistency checking, and scope judgment

Formats covered: Policy reminder, internal announcement, website copy, app error message, and contract clause

Portfolio sample. The passages below are fictional examples written to show editing technique. They are not taken from any employer or client.

How I Edit

Every passage gets the same checks, in this order. The first check matters most: an editor improves the writing without changing what the author said, so anything I cannot verify becomes a query, not an edit.

1. **Accuracy and facts.** Dates, numbers, names, and claims are checked for support. Missing or unclear facts become questions for the author. I do not add facts.
2. **Clarity and structure.** One idea per sentence, the main point first, and an order the reader can follow.
3. **Tone and audience.** The voice matches the brand and the reader, whether that is a formal policy, a friendly announcement, or a short message in an app.
4. **Consistency.** Terms, capitalization, number style, and punctuation match throughout. Decisions are recorded in a style sheet (see below).
5. **Scope.** I stay within the level of edit requested. Legal, technical, and brand-claim questions go to the right person instead of being settled by the editor.

Example 1: Policy Reminder (Internal Communication)

Original text	<i>"Employees should try to submit their expenses on time because if they don't then finance might not be able to process them and this could cause delays and confusion."</i>
Author queries	• The draft says "on time" without defining it. What is the submission deadline? • What is the consequence of a late claim: rejection, delay, or extra checks?
Author response (illustrative)	Five business days from the expense date. Late claims are still accepted but may be delayed or need extra verification.
Revised version	Employees must submit expenses within five business days of the expense date. Late submissions may be delayed or require additional verification from Finance.
Changes made	• Replaced "should try to" with "must", because the author confirmed it is a requirement. • Replaced "on time" with the confirmed deadline. • Removed the "because if they don't then... and this could" chain and stated the confirmed consequence directly. • Used "Finance" with a capital F, matching how the team is named elsewhere in the style sheet.

Example 2: Internal Announcement

Original text	<i>"Hi all!! just a reminder that starting next month basically everyone is going to need to start using the new system for time off requests instead of emailing your manager directly so please make sure you check it out before then because IT said the old process won't really be supported anymore!!"</i>
Author queries	• What is the exact start date? "Next month" becomes unclear when the message is forwarded or read later. • Is the email process switched off completely on that date?
Author response (illustrative)	September 1. Email requests will no longer be supported after that date.
Revised version	Starting September 1, submit all time-off requests through the new PTO system instead of emailing your manager. The email process will no longer be supported after that date. Please log in and review the new workflow before then.
Changes made	• Replaced "next month" with the confirmed date. • Cut filler ("just a reminder," "basically," "make sure you check it out") that added length without meaning. • Split one run-on sentence into three short, direct ones. • Replaced the hedge "won't really be supported" with a clear statement, and removed "IT said" so the message speaks for the company. • Removed the double exclamation marks for a calm, professional tone suited to a company-wide message.

Example 3: Website Copy

Original text	<i>"We are a leading provider of innovative, cutting-edge learning solutions that empower learners to unlock their full potential and achieve their goals through our world-class platform."</i>
Author queries	• "Leading" and "world-class" are claims readers may want evidence for. Can we support them with rankings, awards, or customer numbers, or should we describe what the platform does? • What does the platform include? Please list the main features.
Author response (illustrative)	Short courses, practice quizzes, and progress tracking. Learners study at their own pace.
Revised version	Build new skills at your own pace. Our platform brings short courses, practice quizzes, and progress tracking together in one place.
Changes made	• Replaced unsupported superlatives with the concrete features the author confirmed. • Led with the reader's benefit instead of the company's self-description. • Removed stacked buzzwords ("innovative," "cutting-edge," "unlock their full potential") that say little. • Kept the brand's friendly, direct voice and used "your" to speak to the reader.

Example 4: App Text (Error Message)

Original text	<i>"Oops! Something went wrong!! Please try again later or contact support if the problem persists."</i>
Author queries	- Does the system know what failed (saving, loading, or connecting)? A specific message helps the user act. - Can users reach support from this screen? If so, how?
Author response (illustrative)	It is a save error, usually caused by a lost connection. Support is reachable from the Help menu.
Revised version	We couldn't save your changes. Check your internet connection and try again. If this keeps happening, contact Support from the Help menu.
Changes made	- Removed "Oops!" and the double exclamation marks, which sound casual at the moment a user is frustrated. - Named the problem and gave a next step, so the user knows what to do. - Capitalized "Support" as the team name, per the style sheet. - Kept it to three short sentences that fit a small message box.

Example 5: Contract Language

Scope: I edit contract text for clarity, consistency, and internal references only. What the clause legally means or allows is for the author or counsel to decide, so substantive questions are queried and not settled by the editor.

Original text	<i>"The Customer shall pay all invoices within 30 days and if the Customer doesn't pay on time the Supplier may charge interest on late amounts and may also suspend the services until payment is made."</i>
Author queries	- Does the 30 days run from the invoice date or the date the invoice is received? - Where is the interest rate set? Should the clause point to it? - Is notice required before services are suspended? "Services" is a defined term elsewhere in the contract. Should it be capitalized here?
Author response (illustrative)	From the invoice date. Interest is in clause 9.2. Five days' written notice is required before suspension. Yes, capitalize "Services."
Revised version	The Customer must pay each invoice within 30 days of the invoice date. If payment is late, the Supplier may charge interest on the overdue amount as set out in clause 9.2. After giving five days' written notice, the Supplier may suspend the Services until payment is received.

Changes made	• Split one long sentence into three, so each obligation stands alone. • Replaced "shall" with "must" to match the plain-language style sheet for this document. • Replaced "doesn't pay on time" with "payment is late" and removed the contraction. • Added the confirmed start date for the 30 days, the cross-reference to clause 9.2, and the notice period, all supplied by the author. • Capitalized "Services" to match the defined term.
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Sample Style Sheet

A style sheet records each consistency decision so the same choice is made every time, across documents and across editors. This is an excerpt from the sheet used for the examples above.

Item	Decision	Reason
Numbers	Spell out one to nine, use numerals for 10 and above and for amounts of money	Common house rule; keeps text readable and consistent
Dates	Month and day, no ordinal (September 1)	Shorter and clear to a global audience
Team names	Capitalize (Finance, Support)	Treats team names as proper nouns
email	One word, no hyphen	Current standard usage
Defined terms	Capitalize exactly as defined in the contract (Customer, Supplier, Services)	Keeps legal meaning consistent
Contractions	Avoid in policies and contracts; allowed in friendly web and app text	Matches formality of each format
Exclamation marks	Avoid in announcements and error messages	Calm, professional tone

What I Leave Alone

Good editing is also restraint. In the examples above, I deliberately did not change:

- The author's meaning, or any fact I could not verify. These became queries.
- Brand voice and product terms, such as "PTO system" and "Support," that the audience already knows.
- Legal substance in the contract clause. Only clarity, consistency, and references were edited.
- Intentional repetition or emphasis that serves the reader.